

Unique Umnov

By C.G.S.Narayanan

When white men occupy the squares just vacated by black piece, other than a pawn, as second move continuations in a three-mover we have an Umnov, a unique three-move theme known for its beauty and paradox. The black piece however keeps the possibility of going back to that square with a capture. In the first problem below for study the WNd7 can very well capture either of the BRs but the scheme works only after the WQ forms the white battery with an excellent key granting two flights d7 and e7. After the **key 1.Qb8!** threatening 2.Nb5+ Kd7 The lateral battery on the seventh rank spring into action for the third move mate.

Robert Burger & Robin Matthews
I prize, The Problemist 1994



Mate in three moves

The subtle black defences 1...cRd5 and eRd5 try to disrupt the final mate. 1..cRd5 2.Nc5 using the self-block at d5. If 2...Rxc5 3.Qd8 and 1...eRd5 2.Ne5 Rxe5 3.Qd8. The try move that leaps to the eye 1.Qf8? defeated by somewhat obvious refutation 1...Re3! and the extra variation is 2...Ke7 3.Nf8. A classic exposition of the theme with admirable white economy.

Viktor Lizunov & Andre Lobusov
2 Prize, Shakmaty v SSSR 1991



Mate in three moves

In successive Umnov at least twice in a row a move is played to the just vacated square. **Key 1.Qb4!** 2.Ne2+ fxe2 3.Qc3: 1...Nxd5 2.Rb6 Nc7 3.Rd5# 1...Nxc4 2.Rc5 Nd6 3.Rc4# (1...Nba4 2.Qxc4+)

In the problem for solving below the Umnov square can be easily spotted but the key and the threat are slightly difficult with lot of close tries.

C.G.S.Narayanan
I prize, Macedonian Problemist 2002



Mate in three moves

Solution to problem for solving in the article 'Reversal of mates': Set: 1...Kb1 2.Rd2 (A); 1...cxb3 2.Rd1(B) Key 1.Qa5 (2.Qa2) 1...Kb1 2.Rd1(B); 1...cxb3 2.Rd2 (A) Mate reversal. The by-play 1...Ba4 2.Rh3 adds spice

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